



The Hawaiian Islands

The longest island chain on Earth, where continual volcanic activity has created a unique tropical habitat

Situated in the Pacific Ocean about 2,360 miles (3,800 km) southwest of the continental U.S. and around 3,850 miles (6,200 km) southeast of Japan, the Hawaiian Islands are some of the most remote in the world. At 1,520 miles (2,450 km) long, they also form the world's longest archipelago.

Expanding landscape

The eight main islands and more than 100 islets are part of the Hawaiian Island–Emperor Seamount chain of undersea volcanoes that began to erupt around 70 million years ago. Each main island has one or more volcanoes, and three are currently active on Hawaii itself (see pp.318–19). The constant outpouring of lava is still adding to Hawaii's landmass: it has gained about $\frac{3}{4}$ square mile (2 square km) of land since 1983, created by the continual eruption of Kilauea. Hawaiian animals and plants are as unique as their island homes—more than 90 percent are endemic, but this makes them vulnerable, and the islands contain at least one-third of all listed endangered species of the U.S.



▷ LAVA RIVERS

Hawaii's Kilauea volcano releases 7,000,000–17,650,000 cubic ft (200,000–500,000 cubic m) of lava each day—enough to resurface 20 miles (32 km) of a two-lane road. Fortunately, most of it flows into the sea.

◁ STATE FLOWER

The endangered Hawaiian hibiscus is found on all main Hawaiian islands except Niihau and Kahoolawe, and blooms mainly from spring through early summer.

THE WORLD'S TALLEST VOLCANOES

A mountain's height is usually measured from sea level to summit, but submerged volcanoes are measured from their bases on the sea floor. Hawaii's Mauna Loa is technically the world's tallest volcano. Its base is a depression it created in the seabed, which gives it a total height of 56,332 ft (17,170 m)—more than 27,000 ft (8,230 m) taller than Mount Everest.

